

■ Step-by-Step Guide: Plucking and Processing Chickens

■ What You'll Need:

- 1 Killing cone or restraining method
- 2 Sharp knife or poultry shears
- 3 Large pot or scalding (to heat water to 145–155°F / 63–68°C)
- 4 Thermometer
- 5 Plucking machine (optional)
- 6 Clean table or processing surface
- 7 Bucket or container for feathers and waste
- 8 Garden hose or water source
- 9 Ice chest or cold water bath
- 10 Gloves (optional but recommended)

■ Step 1: Preparation

- 1 Set up your area: You'll need separate stations for killing, scalding, plucking, evisceration (gutting), and chilling.
- 2 Heat water: Fill your pot or scalding with water and heat to 145–155°F (63–68°C).
- 3 Prepare chilling bath: Fill a large container with cold water and ice to chill the processed birds quickly.

■ Step 2: Humane Slaughter

- 1 Place chicken in the killing cone, head first. This calms the bird.
- 2 Expose the neck by pulling the head through the bottom of the cone.
- 3 Using a sharp knife, make a clean cut on both sides of the neck, severing the carotid arteries and jugular veins.
- 4 Let the bird bleed out completely (about 1–2 minutes).

■ Step 3: Scalding

- 1 Dip the bird in hot water (145–155°F) for 30–60 seconds.
- 2 Agitate the bird gently to ensure water penetrates the feathers.
- 3 Test by pulling feathers from the wing — they should come off easily.

■ Step 4: Plucking

- 1 By hand: Start with wing and tail feathers. Work from tail to head.
- 2 With a plucking machine: Turn on the machine and drop the bird in. Let it run 10–30 seconds.
- 3 Rinse the bird with cold water afterward.

■ Step 5: Evisceration (Gutting)

- 1 Remove head and feet using a knife or poultry shears.
- 2 Make a small cut at the vent (anus) and carefully enlarge the opening.
- 3 Reach inside and pull out internal organs in one motion. Set aside liver, heart, and gizzard if keeping.
- 4 Avoid rupturing the gallbladder (green sac on liver).
- 5 Remove lungs (use a lung scraper or fingers).
- 6 Flush the cavity with clean cold water.



■ Step 6: Chilling

- 1 Place the cleaned bird in an ice water bath immediately.
- 2 Let it soak until the internal temperature drops to below 40°F (4°C). This may take 30 minutes to 1 hour.

■ Step 7: Packaging or Resting

- 1 Rest the bird in the fridge for 12–24 hours before freezing or cooking.
- 2 Package and freeze if storing long term.

■ Tips:

- 1 Sanitize all tools and surfaces before and after use.
- 2 Use clean, potable water throughout the process.
- 3 Wear gloves if possible, and wash hands regularly.
- 4 Compost feathers and guts or dispose of responsibly.